

THIS IS TECHNOLOGY, CULTURE AND SCIENCE WITH A DIFFERENCE, AND THAT DIFFERENCE IS USUALLY ENOUGH TO MAKE MOST NORMAL PEOPLE GO "WTF?"

This month in ALT:

In Geek-Key we explore the unique features of Indian Forts, then in DGT we showcase some incredible and exorbitant tech and gadgets from the recent month, and we review the stuff we've been watching on the Internet.



Negative oil prices

On April 20, oil prices went below zero per barrel for the first time in history. Theoretically, traders would pay you money to move oil out of warehouses. So what really happened on the ground on that day? Find out about the disbelief, humour, incredulity and arrogance.

<https://dgit.in/oilzero>

WHAT'S NEW

Twitter limiting people who share links without reading the articles

It might often happen that a story goes viral without anyone actually reading the contents of the article. In an effort to promote informed discussion, Twitter has rolled out an update to some Android users, that asks them if they really intend to share a link that they have not clicked on. The prompt appears when Twitter users retweet an article that they haven't actually opened themselves. This is a widespread problem on social media, where some stories can go viral with only very few people actually reading them. A 2016 study by researchers from Columbia University and Microsoft found that 59 percent of



the links posted on Twitter are never clicked. An article titled "Study: 70% of Facebook users only read the headline of science

stories before commenting" was shared 127,000 times, but the article itself was a half serious social experiment, with the introduction text being variations of the headline, and the remaining paragraph actually being lorem ipsum filler text.

<https://dgit.in/twttrlinks>

IBM to stop offering facial recognition tech

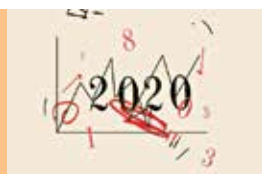
IBM is taking a strong stance when it comes to selling facial recognition technologies to law enforcement agencies, and has very clearly stated that it will no longer be researching, developing or selling general purpose facial recognition technologies, in a letter addressed to the US Congress. The concerns IBM had was that these technologies could be used for mass surveillance, racial profiling or violation of



human rights. IBM has also identified that third party vendors may release products that have not been thoroughly tested for racial bias. For these reasons, IBM has voluntarily committed to cease selling

such products. The letter was penned by IBM CEO Arvind Krishna. The AI deployed in facial recognition technologies often carry the same biases of humans along the lines of age, gender, race and ethnicity. A study conducted in 2018 showed that even for simple tasks such as tagging a gender, AI systems from Microsoft and IBM worked much better on those with lighter skin.

<https://dgit.in/ibmfr>



Rising stocks

In the United States, people are dying from the raging pandemic, there are widespread protests, the GDP is plummeting, but there is a strange, incongruent and consistent trend. The stocks are rising, and things are still somehow working out for the stock markets.

<https://dgit.in/skydow>



What is time?

The human understanding of time has changed over the years. Find out how time has been perceived through the lenses of biology, culture, physics and the practice of timekeeping over human history. This is a timeline of how humans have been looking at time.

<https://dgit.in/timeline>



Hugging during a pandemic

Don't stop a measly little virus from spreading the love, this article shows you safe ways to hug during the pandemic, and to minimise the potential spread of the virus during human contact. It is a good idea to avoid face to face contact, and the safest way to hug is from the back.

<https://dgit.in/panhugs>